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From Classicism to Method: John Dewey and Bernard Lonergan

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The current battle among critics and theorists of American higher education is in fact over the relationship between theory and practice. For a century, however confusedly and with whatever setbacks, classicism has been loosing its grip on education, and on culture in general, and has been replaced by method. William Bennett expressed the fear of many that method means relativism. John Dewey and Bernard Lonergan provide an interpretation of the movement from classicism to method and its significance to education. The chief spokesman for pragmatism and the Jesuit methodologist, for all their differences in other substantive matters, find that education is not a passive acceptance of tradition but a critical appropriation of it. Classics are central to the reconstruction of traditions, but classicism is no longer an adequate explanation of their importance or their place in education.

Just as it has made the horse for racing, the ox for tilling, and the dog for hunting, nature has made man for two things, as Aristotle says, for thinking and acting—as if man were a mortal God. [CICERO, *De Finibus* II.13.40]

In November 1984, the chairman of the National Endowment for the Humanities, William J. Bennett, issued a report on American higher education entitled *To Reclaim a Legacy* (Bennett 1984). In it he reviewed what he takes to be the chaotic and debilitated condition of humanities education in colleges and universities. Bennett's criticisms of higher education are made from a viewpoint that is shared by many who feel that American higher education has betrayed its primary task of transmitting the classics of Western culture and American political history to students, and he unequivocally places the blame for this on the doorstep of the educators themselves.

Of the many points made by Bennett, several appear that are crucial to the cultural functions and aims of higher education. The issues are long-lived and have been argued repeatedly for a century between

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traditionalists and modernists in a variety of contexts, religious, political, legal, literary critical, as well as educational. *Mutatis mutandis*, the issues form the substance of the discussion not only between Bennett and his critics, but also between John Dewey and Robert Maynard Hutchins in the 1930s, between the outstanding fundamentalist theologian, J. Gresham Machen, and his evangelical modernist opponent, Shailer Mathews, in the 1920s, and now between Joseph Cardinal Ratzinger, the prefect of the Vatican's Congregation for the Defense of the Faith, and Father Charles E. Curran, professor of Catholic ethics (Dewey 1937; Hutchins 1937; Machen 1981; Mathews 1969; Curran 1986; Ratzinger 1985). The debate renewed by Bennett swirls around four terms: authority, pluralism, relativism, and method, and beneath them lies the foundational question of the relation between theory and practice.

Marx, in the eleventh of his "Theses on Feuerbach," remarked that the task of philosophy had been to understand the world, whereas its task must be to change it (1964, p. 72). He did not invent the problem of the relation between theory and practice—it is quite clearly operative in the work of David Hume, Immanuel Kant, and G. F. Hegel—but he did pose the problem with a directness that is difficult to dodge. The question has not receded (Lobkowitz 1967). Roman Catholic theologian Matthew Lamb, in his recent book, *Solidarity with Victims: Toward a Theology of Social Transformation*, has this to say about the ubiquity of the problem of theory-practice:

The relationship of theory and praxis goes right to the core of the entire philosophical enterprise; it involves the relationship of consciousness to being, of subject to object, of idea to reality, of word to deed, of meaning to history. Similarly in theology, this relationship goes beyond a discussion of contemplative or active ways of life to raise such fundamental issues as the relations of faith to love, of church to world, of orthodoxy to orthopraxy, of salvation to liberation, of religion to political concerns, of historical and systematic to moral and pastoral theology. Even an adequate bibliography of the theory-praxis relationship in contemporary

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Christian theologies would extend far beyond the limits of the present study. [Lamb 1982, p. 61]

One of the things that has been going forward in higher education is a change in the understanding of the relationship between theory and practice, and what one might call a collapse of classicism and its replacement by method. Bennett (1984) alludes to this. The appreciation and estimate of that shift constitute one of the matters that divides our community in its discussion of higher education and has done so throughout our century. I intend to discuss the thinking of two men who were deeply concerned with the question of theory and practice, men from remarkably different backgrounds and social contexts, and allow them to clarify the terms for us. I shall take them as critics of classicism who had articulated programs to guide its replacement.

Situating Dewey and Lonergan

John Dewey is to American public education as Saint Thomas Aquinas is to twentieth-century Roman Catholic theological education, a patron saint in whose name a variety of pedagogical horrors were worked on several generations of students by disciples who remained faithful to the letter and failed to imitate the creative spirit of the master. Had Dewey been taken with full seriousness, if his eschatological educational theory had been implemented, we would recognize neither our school system nor our society. Had Aquinas's practice of theology as a quest for understanding attracted his commentators, rather than his brilliant conceptual apparatus, which came to serve as fodder for the ecclesiastical educational mills, Catholicism might have earlier made the respectable contribution to modern religious thought that it began to make only in the sixth decade of this century, most prominently in the work of Catholic biblical exegetes and the systematic thought of the Jesuits Bernard Lonergan and Karl Rahner. So pervasive is the influence of Lonergan and Rahner among Catholic theologians that one is tempted to warn their students to avoid an output that parallels in quantity and quality the appalling piles of secondary literature left behind by neo-Thomists and Deweyans. I am kept from such a warning by two considerations: first, the present article is a contribution to two of the piles, and, second, the warning is already too late, for, as the old Catholic adage has it, "The Jesuits have one man to do something and seven to write about him."

In a sense, with Dewey and Lonergan themselves we meet classics. They are concrete universals. Dewey could not be taken for anything other than an American. He was the son of his Puritan forebears, and for his Puritan moralism he was tweaked by George Santayana, who accused him of paying far too much attention to the human foreground and far too little to the cosmic background of our existence, a problem of perspective that Santayana found characteristic of Americans generally (1951, pp. 245–61; 1967). Again, John Randall (1953), in his eulogy, called Dewey a “Yankee saint.” With all its ambiguity, that moment of canonization symbolized the importance of Dewey to the mind and heart of American intellectuals as they have struggled with the transition from rural to urban culture, from individualist capitalism to corporate empire, from liberal arts colleges to the modern university, and, in relation to our topic, from classicism to method.

But Dewey can easily be misunderstood. Although he is typically American in many respects, he was not provincial, not riveted on the “practical” in any lowercase sense, not an ideologue of entrepreneurial bourgeois capitalism and the American empire. He was a critic of American chauvinism and nationalism. He was a communitarian and a socialist, a man engaged with the commonweal, a “philosopher of the common man,” a universalist, an internationalist, an interculturalist. He was and is attacked by Marxists as a bourgeois ideologue because he espoused a reformist socialism that threatened their own corner of the ideological vineyard (Wells 1971; Novack 1975; Gonzalez 1977; Moreno and Frey 1985). Dewey was typically American, and just as deeply universalist, in spirit and thought.

Lonergan was himself something of a Catholic classic, a Roman Catholic cleric, a mind trained in the Jesuit classical and humanist tradition, one who described himself as a doctrinal conservative, and who was influenced decisively by thinkers like Augustine, Aquinas, and Newman (Lonergan 1974*a*, 1974*b*, 1974*c*, 1982). But just as decisively he was indebted to the classical Greeks and to major thinkers of the modern Western world whose names and language crowd the indices to his works. He spent his life reworking large chunks of the Catholic theological and Western philosophical traditions and at the same time laid the theoretical foundations for a dialogue among the world’s religions (Gregson 1985). He was loyal to his church and its tradition, and that very loyalty prompted him to introduce hundreds, perhaps thousands, of younger Catholic thinkers to the historical character of Catholic theology, doctrines, and institutions. And, in the church that has been a great bastion of Western classicism and that has been for centuries the dedicated enemy of the *nova* and the proponent of the

vetera, he announced in unequivocal terms the transition from classicism to method.

I engage in this rhetorical use of the concrete universal because these men, if not great philosophers (I will leave that one to the historians of philosophy), are bridge figures who carry and express the intellectual and spiritual tensions of their times and cultural circumstances, who pointed out how one might get from one age to the next without losing all one's luggage (Shea 1988). To drop the metaphor, both Dewey and Lonergan understood the tension between rapidly changing cultural infrastructure and its creaking theoretic superstructure, and both "solved the problem" in its theoretical and practical phases in similar fashion, by what is called the turn to the subject or methodological self-consciousness. They were not alone in this, and they did not originate the turn, but in their respective contexts they most effectively and insistently made the case (Muck 1968; Coreth 1968; Lonergan 1985*a*, 1985*b*, 1985*c*; Dewey 1916; Bernstein 1971; Rorty 1982).

Dewey, for example, when he felt it necessary to offer some evidence for the enormously complex cognitional theory contained in his *Logic, the Theory of Inquiry* to those unfamiliar with philosophical debates about logic, wrote, "I suggest that such readers interpret what is said by calling to mind what they themselves do, and the way they proceed in doing it" (1938, p. iv). It is precisely Dewey's ability to pay attention to what he himself did in experiencing, understanding, and judging that provides the underpinnings for his philosophical argument on the primacy of method. For all Dewey's reservations about introspection, self-knowledge was the foundation of his philosophical views.

Theory and Practice

Dewey and Lonergan faced the philosophical problem of how the relationship between theory and practice is to be redrawn. Dewey's answer is that the relationship between the two has been essentially solved *practically* or in *praxis*, exhibited in the rise and spread of scientific method and its technological consequences. From this point of view, Dewey divides human history into two eras, the prescientific and the scientific, with the latter characterized by and distinguished from the former precisely by the conviction that ideas are to be tested in action, in "experiment" (Dewey 1960*a*, 1960*b*; Bernstein 1971). The successful ideas always were so tested, of course, but are so now programmatically in science or, more generally, "the method of intelligence."

From this, Dewey generalizes, all human action is either intelligent or unintelligent, and the difference between the two is “experimentalism.” Thus he insists that all activities of human life, all “practices,” should follow the model of the sciences, or scientific method. He followed his own advice, using only “objective factors” in his own philosophical reflection, that is, those aspects of experience that are subject in some broad sense to public scrutiny and experiment. He argued as well that meanings and values are “objective” against his empiricist-positivist critics, many of whom believed them “subjective” and so relative. Dewey’s shibboleth “scientific method,” in other words, meant not the “methods of the sciences” but intelligence used to solve human problems experimentally (1958, 1968*a*, 1968*b*).

Lonergan handles the theory-practice matter differently. The aim of philosophy is self-knowledge and self-appropriation. If the relation between theory and practice is to be understood, one must understand what one does when one theorizes and when one acts, and that sort of knowledge can *only* be attained through a critical mediation and appropriation of one’s own cognitional, evaluative, and decisional processes or operations. As one analyzes the data of sense, so one can analyze the data of consciousness. To uncover what one does when one knows, values, and acts and to take responsibility for it is the effective reconciliation of theory and practice. To reconcile theory and practice in practice, moral and religious conversion are required (Lonergan 1985*b*; 1972, pp. 267–68).

For Lonergan, then, the history of theory and practice does not turn on the rise of scientific method alone or perhaps even chiefly. It turns on the Greek breakthrough to theory, the patristic recognition that one could defend the scriptural meanings in logically precise nonscriptural terms, Augustine’s judgment that God needs no body to be real, the medieval advance to systematic thought in the thirteenth century, Newton’s discovery of classical laws, Kant’s turn to the subject from the object, Hegel’s recognition of the role of meaning in history, the discovery of statistical procedures to complement classical laws, and so forth (Lonergan 1972, pp. 85–99; 1974*b*). What we are dealing with in Lonergan’s view, then, is an ever more precise and systematic differentiation of groups of conscious operations. The philosopher’s problem is to understand the different patterns in relation to one another, resisting our common temptation to reduce one set of operations to another or allow one set of procedures to dominate the others (Lonergan 1957, pp. 181–91; 1972, p. 25). Lonergan’s account of modernity is more subtle than Dewey’s, for Dewey concentrates almost entirely on scientific method understood as experimental.

In addition, there are important conceptual and methodological differences between the two. Dewey would likely view what Lonergan calls the methodical heightening of consciousness that leads to intellectual conversion as an example of introspection and a privatization of the philosophical task. Dewey wrestled mightily with the problem of philosophical method in his early years and considered psychology to be that method and introspection to be an essential part of it. Thus, “psychical science must begin with the facts made known in consciousness” (Dewey 1967, pp. 11–12). But he grew increasingly loath to offer validation of his theoretic claims by an appeal to introspection, tended to speak of consciousness “behaviorally,” and several times voiced caveats about introspective psychology (Dewey 1916, p. 364; 1934, p. 267). But his caveats mislead us, since his texts give evidence that the norm or standard that he used to criticize claims in methodological matters was his own operations, and these are available only to one who attends to them via introspection.

And precisely at this point, in the confusion over whether self-knowledge and self-appropriation are philosophically valid and even necessary moments, Lonergan would view Dewey’s “experimentalism” (i.e., the theory) as a case of unbroken cognitional mythology in which biological extroversion remains the criterion for the real, for, after all, does not the later Dewey’s insistence on knowledge as the outcome of the manipulation of “objective factors” in experience and his turn against introspection as nonscientific tell us that the real is what is “out there” to be manipulated (Adler and Meyer 1958; Lonergan 1957, pp. 411–16; 1972, pp. 238–39)?

Again, for Dewey, philosophy is a critique of culture and a mediation of scientific method to the problems of the human community, while for Lonergan, philosophy is self-criticism, self-knowledge, and self-appropriation that has both communal roots and public consequences. While Lonergan was possessed of an unrelenting drive to bring the reader to self-understanding, Dewey was driven to criticize culture insofar as it is an inadequate or distorted expression of experience. One aim does not exclude the other, of course, and each man in fact met quite well the goal of the other, but the likely suspicion of each about the philosophical horizon of the other tells deeply in his work and makes it easily distinguishable from the other’s.

Finally, there is the issue of transcendence and practice, and the status of the transcendent in existence. For Lonergan, transcendence is a realm of human meaning (i.e., a realm meant by human beings) and is real (1972, pp. 81–85, 265–66). For Dewey, transcendence is a realm of human meaning and is ideal and not real (i.e., existent)

(1934, pp. 39–57; Shea 1984, pp. 61–90). For Lonergan, sin is a deviation from the task of intelligent living devoted to the good, which can be met only in the transformative symbolic language of religious communities; for Dewey, sin is not a category with any public application to human history, and traditional religion is a mistaken, if historically understandable, form of practice. For Dewey, moral evil is real and can only be overcome, to the limited extent that it can at all, by concerted human action for the good. In this instance, Dewey is the thoroughgoing naturalist while Lonergan remains the supernaturalist. For Dewey, the answer to “the problems of men” is, in the final analysis, moral action, while for Lonergan, sin is the root of many problems and can only be met by religious conversion (Dewey 1965; Lonergan 1972). This implies important differences in their readings of history and their theory of education.

But there are as well areas in which Dewey and Lonergan agree, and several of them are important for our consideration of their thought on education and culture. In the first place, their views on the constitution of communities are nearly identical. Communities are constituted by common experience, common meanings, common decisions, and common values. Meanings are maintained and expanded primarily by symbolic communication. Both hold “organic” views of community life, reject “social contract” theories of communal existence, and are markedly critical of liberal individualism (Dewey 1984, pp. 367–72; 1944, pp. 4–5; 1916; Lonergan 1957, pp. 172–244). Dewey’s (1963) political views are archetypally democratic and communitarian, espousing the same sort of vague socialism as the Christian “social gospel” theologians of the progressive period. Lonergan did not express what are ordinarily called political views, but he is unquestionably a communitarian (Kuklick 1985, pp. 230–61; Lonergan 1986).

Lonergan was a communitarian in the sense that Dewey was, namely, in the belief that the economy exists for the community and not for the individuals within it who are best able to manipulate it to their own advantage. I believe that the main thrust of Dewey’s political and social affectivity was established in his experience of New England town life, and that Lonergan’s owes much to his Catholic communitarian heritage, which gave birth as well to the social teachings of the modern popes from Leo XIII to John Paul II, teachings that to this day retain a pronounced suspicion of Western economic and social arrangements (Pope Leo XIII 1891; Pope Pius XI 1931; Pope John XXIII 1961, 1963; Pope Paul VI 1967; Pope John Paul II 1988; Thomas and Morgan-Witts 1984; Neuhaus 1987). It appears to me that, stripped of its antireligious bias and its philosophical exclusion of the tran-

scendent, Dewey's social and political philosophy would receive a respectful reading by the twentieth-century popes, and especially so by John XXIII, Paul VI, and John Paul II.

Second, both view an understanding of scientific method as crucial to a proper understanding of modern culture and of the task of philosophy in it, and both are deeply concerned to work out a "method of intelligence" (Dewey) or a "generalized empirical method" (Lonergan) in relation to scientific method (Dewey 1929, pp. 110–21; 1933; 1916; Bernstein 1971; Lonergan 1972). Dewey tends to regard science as a standard of method, while Lonergan regards it as a clarifying instance, but both agree that intelligence is normative for human action, and that something decisive for understanding intelligence comes to light with the appearance of science in the modern world.

In the third place, for both men praxis is reconstructive or transformative rather than revolutionist. Against Marx, they agree that praxis is meliorist; that is, both eschew violence where there is any other morally significant choice. Dewey admitted its necessity under certain circumstances, while Lonergan tends to speak in Christian religious terms of the "law of the Cross" (Dykhuizen 1973, pp. 152–61, 290–91; Loewe 1977, 1979). Again, for both, social criticism must be joined to the hermeneutical task of "passing on the tradition." To put it in other terms, the text (whatever it may be) has a prospective as well as a retrospective meaning, it is eschatological as well as archeological, moral as well as historical.

Fourth, in several technical questions in philosophy Dewey and Lonergan are in accord, at least on the surface. They both insist that the single largest error of their predecessors in epistemology was to understand knowing on the model of sensing, or to take the metaphor of "looking" to be literally applicable to knowing. The "spectator theory of knowledge" is radically rejected by both, perhaps on somewhat different grounds (Dewey because it negates the active and constructive character of knowing and so because it regards knowing as conformity or correspondence rather than as method, and Lonergan because it confines knowing to the level of the empirical consciousness) (Dewey 1929; Decker 1976; Lonergan 1957). Both launch a vigorous critique of classical metaphysics; both had a go at revising metaphysics, but neither made it central to their work, and Dewey, in the view of some, regretted that he called his effort at it metaphysics (Dewey 1958; Lonergan 1957, pp. 385–594; Hook 1981; Rorty 1977; Edel 1985; Alexander 1980, 1987; Boisvert 1988).

For both the theory of inquiry is prior to metaphysics as a grounding discipline, and for both formal logic is instrumental and of no particular ontological significance (Dewey 1938, pp. 1–22; Lonergan 1957, pp.

380–81, 576–77). For both all knowledge is a mediation and none is immediate (the immediate is knowable but immediacy is not an instance of knowing) (Dewey 1916, p. 16; Lonergan 1972, pp. 76–77), and for both value is mediated while good is immediate (Dewey 1958; Lonergan 1957, 1972). For neither, then, is there knowledge before there is a question and inquiry; and for neither is value emotive and private, and so beyond (or beneath!) criticism.

For both, the existential is primary in philosophy. Freedom, value, choice, action, responsibility, history, community, practice, and self- and world-constitution are the basic interests. For neither man is the basic human relation to existence established *theoretically*. As neither is an empiricist, so neither is a rationalist. To put it in Matthew Lamb's terms, neither man falls under the "primacy of theory model" of the theory-praxis relation (Lamb 1976; Shea 1977). For both praxis is basic.

Classicism and Method

We move now to education, a topic on which, given the similarities, we might expect at least some convergence. For Dewey, education is a critical practice by which the society (in our case, the democratic society) mediates to its members the meanings and values as well as the skills it prizes. It is critical in the sense in which scientific method is critical, that is, that the method itself rather than any conclusion is the norm and that all texts and claims are subject to inquiry, including and especially those considered canonical. Scientific method is not understood as the methods of the sciences, but as the responsible and systematic exercise of empirical intelligence. Education, then, is the process by which the modern democratic community becomes aware of the relationship between idea and action, theory and practice, and so learns what it is to be a "mortal god." There the society shows itself what ideas are for and why they are worthwhile, by promoting the life of the community through reflective action. In the educational process, authority resides neither in the text nor in the teacher but in the praxis itself (Dewey 1944, p. 76). Education is praxis, and by that Dewey means thinking and acting in a self-correcting, experimental process.

For Lonergan, education is a means by which the community mediates to its members the meanings and values that constitute it. Education mediates what it means to be human. In a community possessed of differentiated consciousness, education is the context in which recognition and appropriation of the subject's subjectivity is a primary

goal. The meanings and values of the community are carried in its literature, its arts, and its traditional history (i.e., its classics) and are appropriated there, while the appropriation of subjectivity takes place in philosophical reflection under whatever academic name. The content of this appropriation includes one's affectivity, intelligence, rationality, and responsibility and their intrinsic and transcendental norms, which have communal as well as individual significance. Personal and communal authenticity guides the critical evaluation of tradition, and the reconstitution and transformation of the community's life. Education itself is an instance of praxis, the norms of which are the transcendental imperatives of attentiveness, intelligence, reasonableness, and responsibility. Philosophy of education has as its primary task educating the educators in transcendental method and its educational implications. In fact, the point of philosophy of education is not to answer pedagogical, social, or political questions, but rather to broaden the horizon of the educators, "the ones who run the bureaucracy" as well as the teachers, to bring them from their private worlds into "the universe of being" wherein they can face pedagogical, social, and political questions (Lonergan 1979, p. 135).

Both Dewey and Lonergan recognize classicism as an inadequate theory of education. Classicism is a view of political, social, religious, and intellectual life that takes classics (the proximate locus or carrier of traditions) as norms, as definitive answers to life's questions, answers that need only be absorbed for one to find life understood and action directed. Classics become a sacred literature, education its process of absorption, and life its imitation. Lonergan describes classicism in terms acceptable to Dewey:

On the older view culture was conceived not empirically but normatively. It was the opposite of barbarism. It was a matter of acquiring and assimilating the tastes and skills, the ideals, virtues, and ideas, that were pressed upon one in a good home and through a curriculum in the liberal arts. It stressed not facts but values. It could not but claim to be universalist. Its classics were immortal works of art, its philosophy was the perennial philosophy, its laws and structures were the deposit of the wisdom and the prudence of mankind. Classicist education was a matter of models to be imitated, of ideal characters to be emulated, of eternal verities and universally valid laws. It sought to produce not the mere specialist but the *uomo universale* that could turn his hand to anything and do it brilliantly. [Lonergan 1972, p. 301]

This is precisely what higher education has abandoned. What has taken its place is a matter of debate. Bennett and others are convinced

that relativism has done so. But if Dewey and Lonergan are correct, education is in transition not from absolutism to relativism but from classicism to method, no matter how imprecisely and incoherently the latter is formulated in current theory and practice of education. While the text is vital to the educational process, the self-understanding and appropriation of the interpreter is primary. The text is interpreted and not conformed unto, meaning is constituted and not delivered, responsibility is taken on and not imposed, and in each case in terms of the norms derived from the intentional operations themselves. The given has become the questioned.

Current Arguments

With this foundation laid, I will now address briefly the terms that I selected from my reading of Secretary Bennett's report. First, while Bennett seems to limit education to a formative role in culture, Dewey and Lonergan suggest that higher education serves a transformative as well as formative role in a culture. I draw the usage of the terms "formation" and "transformation" from Rosemary Haughton, who regards the two as essential functions of religious language. Formation transmits a pattern of language and action, while transformation makes possible development, renewal, and change in that pattern. This is one way of distinguishing classicism and method in higher education. For classicism the tradition transmitted is the norm to which the student must conform; for method the student's own intelligence and reasonableness are the norm that makes possible a critical appropriation of the tradition (Haughton 1967; Lonergan 1985*d*, pp. 5–12).

Thus, education is critical in two senses. It is critical insofar as it heightens the possibility of self-criticism. In Lonergan's terminology, higher education aims at self-understanding and self-appropriation, at intellectual and moral authenticity, at the praxis that calls for authenticity and reinforces it. When Lonergan uses the term "praxis" the moral connotations are prominent, and they apply to the search for truth as a value in the intellectual pattern of experience that higher education means to establish, as well as to the other values by which we determine our lives and take responsibility for them (Lonergan 1979, p. 97; Crowe 1985). Dewey approaches this understanding of the aims of education when he writes of education as a process of reconstruction of experience, of the shaping of habits, of the introduction to meaning, and of the reflective establishment of values (Dewey 1956, p. 81; 1944, pp. 27–30).

But education is a criticism of culture and traditions as well. Lonergan urges those who consider theology as a praxis that they practice the hermeneutics of suspicion as well as the hermeneutics of recovery, and, according to his students, Matthew Lamb the most prominent of them in this regard, that includes a critique of the social, economic, and political order (Lonergan 1985*c*, pp. 160–61; Lamb 1982). Dewey, of course, whose “solidarity with victims” we could all well envy, was an irrepressible critic of political, social, and economic orders, of democracies and totalitarianisms, and of Western religions, in the light of a critically established democratic ideal. He took criticism to be the chief task of both philosophy and educational institutions. He took education to be the laboratory of social criticism:

It is the business of the school environment to eliminate, so far as possible, the unworthy features of the existing environment from influence upon mental habitudes. It establishes a purified medium of action. Selection aims not only at simplifying but at weeding out what is undesirable. Every society gets encumbered with what is trivial, with dead wood from the past, and with what is positively perverse. The school has the duty of omitting such things from the environment which it supplies, and thereby doing what it can to counteract their influence in the ordinary social environment. By selecting the best for its exclusive use, it strives to reinforce the power of this best. As a society becomes more enlightened, it realizes that it is responsible *not* to transmit and conserve the whole of its existing achievements, but only such as make for a better future society. The school is its chief agency for the accomplishment of this end. [Dewey 1944, p. 20]

Neither philosopher negated the past. Rather, both broke the grip of the past on the present. In approaching the past, Dewey leaned strongly to the hermeneutics of suspicion and Lonergan to the hermeneutics of restoration, but neither lacked appreciation for the rectitude and value of the other approach. Both understood education as the reflective review of traditions, of givens. There was as much steel in Lonergan’s criticism of the conceptualism of the Thomist tradition as there was sensitive appreciation of the Greek intellectual achievement in Dewey’s criticism of its supporting social and political injustice (Dewey 1929; Lonergan 1985*e*). No classic, whether the Christian scripture or the United States Constitution, and no institution, can escape the historical and evaluative review that higher education is commissioned to give them (Shea 1989*a*).

Second, Secretary Bennett made a connection between pluralism and relativism, accepting pluralism (at least verbally and none too

enthusiastically) and denouncing relativism. Bennett maintained that faculties and administrators have adopted what amounts to a philosophically relativist stand in the face of the pluralism of American culture. Bennett wants American culture unified by means of a canon of classics. It is not clear that he wants the classics reinstated dogmatically. If I read him correctly he asks educators to assess and take a position on what is important, what is worthwhile and worth interpretation. His preferences are clear, but this does not mean that he would not expect to argue a case, and I trust that would be a scholarly case, not a dogmatic one.

But whether Bennett is a classicist or not is of little relevance to our discussion. His charge about professors and administrators is straightforward:

A collective loss of nerve and faith on the part of both faculty and academic administrators during the late 1960s and early 1970s was undeniably destructive of the curriculum. When students demanded a greater role in setting their own educational agendas, we eagerly responded by abandoning course requirements of any kind and with them the intellectual authority to say to students what the outcome of a college education ought to be. With intellectual authority relinquished, we found that we did not need to worry about what was worth knowing, worth defending, worth believing. The curriculum was no longer a statement about what knowledge mattered; instead it became the product of a political compromise among competing schools and departments overlaid by marketing considerations. . . . Intellectual authority came to be replaced by intellectual relativism as a guiding principle of the curriculum. Because colleges and universities believed they no longer could or should assert the primacy of one fact or one book over another, all knowledge came to be seen as relative in importance, relative to consumer or faculty interest. The desired ends of education changed from knowledge to "inquiry," from content to "skills." . . . Failure to address content allows colleges and universities to beg the question of what an educated man or woman in the 1980s needs to know. The willingness of too many colleges to act as if all learning were relative is a self-inflicted wound that has impaired our ability to defend our subjects as necessary for learning or important for life. [Bennett 1984, pp. 19–20]

There is no doubt that Bennett emphasizes Western culture as the central subject matter of our educational system, and he is clearly not a cultural universalist interested in the thousand intercultural flowers that may be picked. It is also clear that he wants most and perhaps

all students in American institutions of higher education bound to study the Western classics and American political documents. Again, note the contrast he makes between knowledge and inquiry, between content and skills. Inquiry and skills are terms frequently associated with the progressive education movement that claims Dewey's parentage, and with Dewey's instrumentalism and pragmatism. Bennett recognizes, however dimly, the shift from classicism to method and disapproves of it. At the very least he knows the importance of his culture and its texts, and that there can be no discussion where there is no common text (McIntyre 1990).

About the fact of pluralism of meanings and values on campus, and that it is among the serious problems that face educators, Bennett is, in my view, undoubtedly correct. But I find the link Bennett makes between pluralism and relativism unconvincing. In the first place, the philosophical naturalism under which academics operate most of the time, and which was most fully articulated in our century by Dewey, is not in any philosophically significant sense relativist, except in an absolutist reading. By this I mean that the absolutist is bothered that the sort of knowing we seem to prize and trade in the academy is conditioned rather than unconditional, probable rather than certain, and that the process of learning is self-correcting. While much of the world of theory is a matter of understanding rather than judgment, and a matter of judgments of possibility and probability rather than certainty, judgments *do* occur in university disciplines, and they are at least sometimes correct (i.e., in Lonergan's terms, virtually unconditioned; in Dewey's, warrantably assertable). In fact, nothing so distinguishes the authentic scholar from the amateur and the pretender as the finely honed ability to discern the difference in practice between the possible, the probable, and the certain, and even we duller academic sorts can in the long run tell the scholars from the others. When the scholar makes his or her informed judgment, relativism is undone by implication.

The kinds of understanding and judgment peculiar to the academic operation contribute to the notion that the academy is drowning in a sea of relativism, but they are not alone in creating the impression. Academic judgment is also specialized, and the specialist refrains from judgments outside his or her field, and so I am loath to say which political and literary classics *must* be studied by students in general education, while I wouldn't have trouble drawing up and defending a list of ten indispensables in religious studies. As I respect the prior rights of the specialist in a field other than my own, so I protect my rights in the field of religion. I regard my opinion about the relative value of classics in another field to be an instance of common sense

or, worse yet, ignorance and quite possibly infected with the common American bias against the expert. We know more and more about less and less, the adage has it, and no where is this as true as it is in the university. Finally, it appears that the general academic common sense has turned away from canons and classics and toward method, and it is this common sense, rather than any “failure of nerve,” that brings on what Bennett prefers to call relativism (Shea 1989a).

If the reader can abide it, I would offer anecdotal evidence. There are few *philosophical* relativists—and many practical relativists in the sense discussed above—among the academics I have worked with over the past 20 years. Most are utterly convinced that some of their beliefs are correct and the contrary beliefs of their confreres are incorrect. In the fray, their relativism is quickly shed. There may be a Wittgensteinian fideist or two abroad who try to render philosophically consistent the hesitations and confusions of their confreres—Richard Rorty comes to mind—but I wonder if even they think that their cultural relativism is only relatively true. The problem in academia is, in my view, not a lack of insight, principles, convictions, or values, or even certainty, but of the willingness, the energy, the context, and the language for communicating and debating them (Shea 1989a, 1989b).

There is a perceptible failure—this, too, is widely reported—in the democratic community of educationists, a failure of the political community and of communication across lines of specialties. Now, it is a question whether American academic institutions ever were in any significant sense democratic, and surely about just what that desideratum might mean in the concrete, but I do not think that certain claims are open to serious challenge: namely, that educational institutions now support considerable bureaucracy, that the campus has lost its communal intellectual and political life, that the professors have become professionals whose loyalty is far more to professional organizations than to the campus, and that faculties no longer think they significantly influence the directions of their institutions. This seems securely documented (Boyer 1987). But the facts raise the question whether this malaise is simply the unavoidable price we pay for professional management of large institutions and for professorial specialization, or whether one should make a fuss about a situation in need of reform.

My belief is that the weakened state of democratic communication among faculty members and administrators on common problems is more a function of bureaucracy and specialization than it is of the “failure of intellectual nerve” and the relativism claimed by Bennett. We can soon enough find out, at any rate, if faculties were to take pluralism seriously enough to evolve ways of critically evaluating their differences. There is need of some form of communal critical review

in which what Lonergan calls “dialectic” would play a prominent part (1957, p. 401–30; 1972, pp. 235–66). Some disagreements are basic, and they need to be faced if a community is to exist around them. Some are important and need attention. Some are doubtless inconsequential. At any rate, if the faculties and administrators actually think there is or should be something they constantly refer to as the “campus community,” then Dewey’s point that communities are constituted by common interests and communication can be used a criterion for judgment, and perhaps for reform. Praxis, here taken as intelligent criticism of the community, might well be turned on the community that is to be a primary carrier of it in the culture. I take Bloom’s (1987) *Closing of the American Mind*, Bennett’s (1984) *To Reclaim a Legacy*, Boyer’s (1987) *College*, Bok’s (1986) *Higher Learning*, and Crowe’s (1985) *Old Things and New*, among many others, to be opportunities that should be capitalized upon on campuses.

There remains a comment on the fourth term mentioned at the outset, the locus of cultural authority. Bennett bemoaned the shift of attention on the part of academics from content to method, and he may mean by the latter “technique.” Neither Lonergan nor Dewey thinks that method is a technique in the sense that its use by standardized rules produces a standard product. But let us allow them to set the context again.

Philosophy of education for Dewey amounted to a critique of the dominance of American public education by formal logic, of word study as the method of education, of the elitist obsession with texts (classic and otherwise), of didactic pedagogy untouched by the lesson of scientific method that knowing comes through doing, and of the control of education by economic interests. His problem with educational institutions is that they became a home for conventional wisdom rather than for reflection, for indoctrination in rather than reconstruction of traditions. By loosing the notion of “method” from scientific methods (and democratic praxis from scientific practice), he hoped to force a reconstruction of the methods of education.

The sometimes-disruptive replacement of classicism by method did not mean for Dewey that classics are dispensable. Literature, fine arts, and history present the very possibility of the imaginative reconstruction at the heart of education. Tradition, when it is dethroned as authority, remains a source and a starting point. Dewey does not “technicize” intelligence and culture; rather, he presents us with an aesthetic of human existence (Alexander 1987).

Lonergan engaged a Catholic educational system with philosophy and theology at its apex, devoted to neo-scholastic formalism and conceptualism, to Aristotelian and Thomist logical analysis as its meth-

odological ideal, and to truth as supraempirical, static, and unchanging, and he called its attention to the generative source of systems, namely, intelligence on the move, the intelligence that assesses as well as creates and lives by classics.

They had at least in this regard a common proposal. They upended the traditional Enlightenment subordination of practice to theory and argued that the notion of “method” be taken as the theory of practice. They reconciled theory and practice in this way: they understood that theory is generated from practice, that theory is necessary for practice (necessary insofar as any necessity obtains in a historical order), they accorded primacy to praxis, and they granted theory its autonomy, its independence through criteria and norms intrinsic to it.

They explained this shift differently one from the other. Method, the operations of a self-conscious and responsible person, controls classicism without banishing the classics through its recognition of its own historical character and the historicity of all its human products. The primacy of praxis implies this. In fact, as Lonergan once remarked, classicism’s claim to the normativity of its culture is undone simply by travel. In both men, the fundamental recognition is of the human generation and maintenance of cultures, and of human responsibility for their decline. Classicism, while it survives in such an intellectual climate, is endlessly on the defensive and now must battle for what it wishes to take for granted. Announcing the deterioration of education and railing against the relativists is a classicist’s mode of mourning (Bloom 1987). Equally, celebrating the joys of relativism and the promise of irony in the life of the elite is premature, perhaps even an easy way out of a difficult social and political, not to say intellectual, problem (Rorty 1989).

Higher education, for all its shortcomings, has suffered the shift from sacred text to method, from the normative to the empirical notion of culture, and to intellectual and spiritual pluralism with remarkable success. All of these matters are now in fact assumptions and the conventional wisdom of the academic enterprise no matter how inadequately they may be understood. The question that remains is whether “method” can be exploited sufficiently well intellectually and politically to underpin a badly needed dose of public dialectic on the aims and the curriculum of higher education.

This dialectic requires, I think, not only a clearheaded review of the conditions of higher education that foster a breakdown of a common understanding of its task and procedures (bureaucracy and specialization among them), but also a renewed debate on basic anthropological issues on the nature of human beings, on what it means to experience, to understand, to judge, and to decide. I do not think we can hope

for a universally accepted answer to such questions, but I do think we can clarify the options, take positions, seek for the root of differences, and get about *one* of the tasks which institutions of higher education might take on, self-criticism and self-appropriation.

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